

Word-count declaration

Manuscript: *A Comparability Protocol for Benchmarking Relational Database Access Layers in Express.js* (submission build `ist_main.tex`).

The official IST journal policy confirms a **15,000-word maximum for research papers**. The current author guidance supplied with this revision additionally assigns **200 words to each figure or table** and counts references and manuscript appendices. This declaration uses a deliberately conservative implementation of that rule.

Component
Seven body sections (<code>texcount</code> sum, including headings and caption text in those files)
Structured abstract (<code>texcount</code> sum)
Remaining front matter and required declarations
Main-text tables and figures (1×200)
Rendered reference list (65 entries after removing 12 uncited ones; <code>pdftotext</code> count from the first entry to the last)
Conservative IST submission equivalent

The controlling total is therefore **14,986 words**, leaving **14 words of headroom** under the 15,000-word limit. The structured abstract contains 291 words under the `texcount` sum convention, below 300 words.

Against the previous declaration of 26 July 2026 (14,987 words, 13 words of headroom), the body rose from 11,213 to 12,062 words while the float allowance fell from 1,000 to 200. The revision added material on request — an operational definition of comparability, a protocol-development chronology, an RQ2 leave-one-out sensitivity analysis, statistical-assumption statements, and treatment-selection and audit-corpus scoping — and paid for it structurally rather than by deletion. The full normative protocol specification, the protocol figure, the chronology, the RQ2 sensitivity table, the protocol-to-interpretation mapping, the prior-work coverage table, and the insert results moved to the online supplement (Sections and Tables S48–S52, Figure S5); implementation mechanics for admission, reset, generator, and documentation capture moved with them. No caveat, limitation, or threat-to-validity statement was removed; two that appeared in both Methods and Threats were consolidated to a single statement with a cross-reference. One main-text float remains, the deep-fetch results table.

Every `tabular` in the body now sits inside a numbered, captioned float, so the float allowance cannot be disputed: an earlier unnumbered tier schematic was folded into prose for exactly that reason.

The remaining headroom is 14 words. Any further addition requires an offsetting cut, and this declaration must be regenerated with it.

This total is intentionally stricter than a research-content-only count. It includes all required declaration text even though such text is commonly treated as submission metadata. It also retains caption words already encountered by `texcount` and then assigns the full 200-word allowance to every rendered float, so it does not undercount captions. The paper has no manuscript appendices. The separately submitted `supplement.pdf` is online supplementary material, not an appendix embedded in the research paper.

Reproduction commands (run from `paper/ist`):

```
texcount -sum -brief ../sections/*.tex          # body sections
sed -n "43,68p" ist_main.tex | texcount -sum -brief - # structured abstract
texcount -sum -brief ist_main.tex                # abstract + front matter
grep -cF '@writefile{lot}' ist_main.aux          # numbered tables
```

```
grep -cF '@writefile{lof}' ist_main.aux          # numbered figures
grep -c '^bibitem' ist_main.bbl                  # reference entries
pdftotext ist_main.pdf - | tr -d '\f' | sed -n '/^References$/, $p' | wc -w
```

Front matter and declarations are the third command minus the second.

Count date: 30 July 2026. Any later prose or float change requires this declaration to be regenerated.